

The Hand That Gives

*PIE *der- ‘hand, open palm’ and the body-part origin of the give/take root
A study in the etymology of Greek δῶρον, Hittite dā-, and Celtic *durnos*

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Abstract

This paper proposes PIE **der-* “hand, open palm” as the body-part etymon underlying the give-verb family traditionally reconstructed as **deh₃-* “to give.” The proposal is made not as a challenge to the standard reconstruction but as a positive contribution to an acknowledged gap: **der-* (= **de-* + locative **-r-*) and the give-verb **deh₃-* (= **de-* + verbal extension **-h₃-*) are siblings, both derivatives of the bare hand-element **de-*, as demonstrated in Papers 2 and 3 of this project. Paper 1’s contribution is the lexical evidence for the nominal branch.

The case rests on three observations. First, Greek δῶρον is attested simultaneously in two senses in the earliest layer of Greek literature — “gift” and “palm-breadth” — and the Hesychian gloss δάρυς/ δάρειπ “span of all fingers” preserves the zero-grade alternant of the same word in the same body-part domain. Beekes’s two-lemma solution — treating gift-sense and palm-breadth sense as unrelated entries — is an editorial decision, not an explanation. Second, the Celtic hand-words **dorn/dwrn/dourn* “fist” and **derna/déarna* “palm” form a coherent ablaut pair with a documented PIE singulative formation, confirmed by the transparent compounds **arddwrn* “wrist” and **imdorn* “sword hilt.” Third, Latvian **dūre* “fist” (long *ū* reflecting earlier **uH*, on Schrijver’s analysis) enters the cluster from a third branch. Schrijver (1995: 58) lists these forms as “possible cognates” of Welsh **dwrn* and describes the formal relation between the Greek alternants as “obscure.” Our hypothesis is one possible answer to that openly acknowledged question.

The semantic argument is independently supported by Norbruis (2021: 243–249), who argues on Anatolian morphological grounds that the original meaning of the root reconstructed as **deh₃-* was “to take,” not “to give” — consistent with a body-part origin in which the hand that takes and the hand that gives are two perspectives on a single physical act.

1. The question

Three features of the standard treatment of the PIE give-verb family have stood out as puzzling for well over a century, and none has received a fully satisfying answer.

First. Greek δῶρον is attested in two senses in the earliest layer of Greek literature: as the standard Homeric word for a valued object exchanged between persons or dedicated to a deity, and as a unit of metrological measurement equal to four finger-widths and one-quarter of a foot. The metrological sense appears in *Iliad* 4.109, in Hesiod’s *Works and Days*, in Nikander’s *Theriaca*, in Vitruvius (*De architectura* 2.3.3), and in Pollux’s *Onomasticon* (2.157), with ancient metrological lexicographers through Hultsch (1882: 34–35) treating it as a stable ancient unit. Beekes’s *Etymological Dictionary of Greek* (2010) resolves the puzzle editorially, treating the gift-sense and the palm-breadth sense as two separate lemmata. This is a decision, not an explanation. It leaves unanswered why the archaic Greek word for “gift” is phonologically identical to the archaic Greek word for the width of an open palm, in the same authors.

Second. The give/take polarity across branches: Hittite *dā-* “to take,” Greek δίδωμι “I give,” Latin **dō* “I give,” Sanskrit **dádāti* “he gives.” The standard account calls this “differential retention” and moves on. Norbruis (2021: 243–249), on Anatolian morphological grounds entirely independent of any reconstruction question, has argued that the original meaning was “to take” and that the give-meaning is a post-Anatolian innovation running through an intermediate stage “to bring/deliver.” The semantic picture is one of concrete physical handling as the original, with abstract transference as secondary. A body-part origin — the hand that reaches toward and the hand that extends

outward — fits this picture naturally.

Third. Schrijver (1995: 58), in the most authoritative current monograph on British Celtic historical phonology, lists Greek δῶρον “length of the hand,” Hesychian δάρις, Old Irish **dorn*, Welsh **dwrn*, Breton **dorn/dourn*, Gaulish *Durnomagus*, and Latvian **dūre* as “possible cognates” of Welsh **dwrn*, and notes that “the formal relation between δωρ- and δαρ- is obscure.” This is a recognized comparative set in the current specialist literature, with an acknowledged unsolved etymology. Our hypothesis is a possible answer to a question Schrijver himself flagged as open.

2. The proposal and the three-paper framework

PIE **der-* was the original word for “hand” or “open palm.” It is a regular CeRC root, conforming to PIE root-structure constraints, and participates in the standard ablaut system:

Grade	Form	Distribution
Full (e-grade)	<i>*der-</i>	Base nominal and verbal stem
O-grade	<i>*dor-</i>	O-grade noun base; verbal present stem
Lengthened o-grade	<i>*dōr-</i>	Strong verbal stem; nominal <i>*dōr-on</i>
Zero grade	<i>*d̥r-</i>	Weak stem; <i>*d̥r-n-</i> in singulative formations

From the lengthened o-grade nominal **dōr-on* (with neuter **-on* suffix) comes Greek δῶρον in both its attested senses: the metrological “palm-breadth” is the body-part meaning preserved unchanged; the “gift” is the social extension, that which the open palm holds out and offers. The Celtic languages preserve the root with the PIE singulative suffix **-n-*, giving separate words for the open hand (full grade **dern-ā*) and the closed fist (zero grade **d̥r-no-*). The verbal stem **dor-/dōr-*, with coda-*r* absorbed before consonant-initial personal endings, gives the long vowel attested across Greek, Latin, Sanskrit, and Hittite.

This paper is the first in a three-paper project. Paper 2 (Chavis & Claude 2026b) argues that the PIE contrastive suffix **-tero-* descends from the same pre-PIE hand-element via the grammaticalization pathway HAND > SIDE > BINARY-SPATIAL-CONTRASTIVE. Paper 3 (Chavis & Claude 2026c) decomposes **der-* itself into two independently attested morphemes: a bare hand-element **de-* (attested as the directional particle **de/do* “to, toward” across the IE family, and preserved most directly as the Greek allative clitic *-δε* productive in Mycenaean Greek by 1400–1200 BCE) plus a locative/spatial extension **-r-*. Paper 3 also identifies the give-verb **deh₃-* as a parallel verbal derivative: **de-* + **-h₃-*, where the laryngeal is a derivational verbal extension suffix rather than a root-internal constituent of an unanalyzable primitive.

The consequence is important. We are not arguing that **deh₃-* must be jettisoned or that the laryngeal reconstruction is wrong. We are arguing that **der-* and **deh₃-* are *siblings*: both derivatives of the same bare **de-*, with **-r-* yielding the nominal body-part word and **-h₃-* yielding the verbal give-stem. The /i/-reduplication of δίδωμι, the Greek vowel triple (δοτός/θετός/πατήρ), and the Hittite paradigm all belong to the verbal morphology of **deh₃-* and are not costs for the nominal reconstruction proposed here. Paper 1’s job is to document the body-part evidence for the nominal branch. Papers 2 and 3 extend the argument from there.

We write the root as **der-* with original *d-*, following the consistent *d-* vocalism of the lexical cognates. The *t-* of the grammaticalized suffix **-tero-* reflects regular suffix-initial devoicing of *d-* in the PIE morphological system, as argued in Paper 2 §4.3. The notation **t/d-er-* used in earlier versions of this project is retired.

3. The Greek evidence

3.1 δῶρον: one word, two senses

The word δῶρον appears in Homer and Hesiod with both meanings simultaneously. As a gift or

votive offering, it is the standard Homeric word for a valued object exchanged between persons or dedicated to a deity. As a metrological unit — the width of the open hand, equivalent to four finger-widths and one-quarter of a foot — it appears in *Iliad* 4.109, Hesiod’s *Works and Days*, Nikander’s *Theriaca* 398, Vitruvius’s *De architectura* 2.3.3, and Pollux’s *Onomasticon* 2.157 (s.v. ὀρθόδωρον “straight-hand” — the distance from wrist to fingertips).

Vitruvius supplies the most explicit ancient testimony to the inseparability of the two senses: *δῶρον Γραεκι appellant palmum, quod munus datio graece δῶρον appellatur, id autem semper geritur per manus palmam* (*De architectura* 2.3.3). His causal chain runs: the palm-breadth unit is called δῶρον because gift-giving is always performed through the open palm. He records that an ancient speaker with both senses live in his own usage found them etymologically inseparable, and located the link in the open palm. The directionality of his folk etymology (gift → palm-breadth) is the reverse of ours; the perceived semantic unity is the relevant datum.

A direct ancient witness for the body-part sense, independent of the metrological tradition, is Pollux’s *Onomasticon* 2.144, where δῶρον is recorded as an anatomical term for the front part of the palm. This lemma sits within Pollux’s catalogue of human body-part vocabulary. Even if a skeptic treats the metrological sense as a folk-etymological back-formation from the gift-word, the Pollux 2.144 attestation independently records δῶρον as a body-part term. The body-part sense is attested twice in the *Onomasticon* — at 2.144 anatomically and at 2.157 metrologically — and the compound ὀρθόδωρον confirms that δῶρον in this sense was a productive base for compound formation in the body-part domain.

These are not two words that happen to sound alike. They are the same word at two stages of its semantic history: first the open palm as a body part, then the width of that palm as a unit of measure, then what the open palm holds out as an offering. The coexistence of both senses in the earliest layer of Greek literature is the historical record of a word whose concrete physical meaning was still alive even as its social meaning had become dominant.

3.2 δάρις/δάρις: the zero-grade nominal

Greek preserves a dialectal word δάρις/δάρις, glossed in Hesychius as “span of all fingers” (Attic equivalent σπιθαμή). On our analysis this is the zero grade of **der-* with a nominal suffix: **dɹ-* with syllabic **ɹ* vocalizing as *a* before the suffix, exactly as **pɹH-* gives πατήρ-stem forms with α-vocalism in the zero grade. Three Greek nominal forms attest the body-part domain: δῶρον (o-grade nominal, palm-breadth), δάρις (zero-grade nominal, full hand-span), and δάνος (n-stem alternant, gift/loan). All three are independently attested in Greek; none requires positing an absent consonant.

Frisk’s *Griechisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch* (GEW I: 430–431) treats δάρις/δάρις as the i-stem derivative of δῶρον in its “palm-breadth” sense, with *δαρ-* treated as the ablaut alternant of the *δωρ-* found in δῶρον. The *Diccionario Griego-Español* (DGE) makes the comparative argument explicit: the entry on δάρις states that the forms “hacen verosimil una alternancia **deH₃r-* > *δωρ-* / **d°H₃r-* > *δαρ-*.” Two independent specialist sources — Frisk working on Greek-internal evidence, Schrijver working on Celtic — recognize this as a coherent comparative set whose internal phonological derivation is unsolved. We propose **der-* “hand” as a possible solution.

3.3 δάνος and the r/n-heteroclite

Greek δάνος “gift, loan” is morphologically analyzable as the n-stem alternant of the same root. In the PIE r/n-heteroclite pattern — exemplified by **wód-ɹ/*wéd-ns* “water” — neuter nouns alternate between **-r-* in the nominative/accusative singular and **-n-* in the oblique cases. **dor-on* (r-stem) and **dor-n-* (n-stem, giving δάνος after regular phonological development) are exactly this pattern. The Celtic forms preserve the n-stem in the body-part domain (**dorn/*dwrn* “fist”); Greek preserves the r-stem in the gift domain (δῶρον) and the n-stem in both gift (δάνος) and body-part senses. The apparent semantic split between “gift” and “hand” tracks an inherited derivational structure, not coincidence.

4. The Celtic evidence

4.1 The cognate cluster as a published comparative set

Schrijver (1995: 58, entry 7) provides the canonical specialist treatment. His summary: “Possible cognates are Gr. δῶρον “length of the hand,” δάρις (Hesych.) “id.,” Latv. *dūre*, *dūris* (with long *u*, presumably < **uH*) “fist” (Pok. 203, with criticism). ... The formal relation between δῶρ- and δαρ- is obscure, however.” Three things are established. First, the comparative cluster is a recognized set with Pokorny’s *IEW* (203) as its standard published form. Second, the Indo-European etymology is *open*: Schrijver calls the formal relation “obscure” and the etymology “problematic.” Third, the Celtic *u*-vocalism is, on the standard reading (Jackson 1953, Pokorny, DGVB), original — the Gaulish forms *Durnomagus*, *Durnacos*, *Dagodurnus*, recorded in first-century Continental Celtic, already have *u* before any Brythonic raising rule could apply.

Path A. If we follow Morris Jones (1913: 87), the Brythonic *u*-vocalism arises by Celtic-internal raising of **o* > **u* before **rn*, and the underlying form is **d̥r-no-* from the zero grade of **der-*. Schrijver (1995: III.2.3) tested the rule systematically and rejected it as a regular sound change; Path A requires reviving a position with named historical advocates but not current consensus support.

Path B. If we follow Schrijver and the majority, the Celtic *u* is original. The underlying root shape is **deuH-r-* or **duH-r-*. Under this view, Beekes’s observation that “both branches point to PIE **u*” is not an objection but evidence about the original root shape. δῶρον comes from the full grade **deuH-r-* via Schrijver’s own suggested **du-* > *δ-* mechanism (cf. δώδεκα < **duō-*); the zero grade **duH-r-* gives Celtic **durno-* and Latvian **dūre*.

The substantive thesis — that the cognate cluster reflects a body-part root meaning “hand” or “open palm” from which the give-verbs descend — survives either path. We retain the label **der-* for continuity with the historical literature, noting that Path B would refine the root shape to **deuH-r-*.

4.2 The morphological evidence

Whichever path is preferred, the Celtic morphology is striking:

Form	Language	Meaning	Reconstruction
* <i>dorn</i> , * <i>dwrn</i> , * <i>dourn</i>	Old Irish, Welsh, Breton, Cornish	fist, hand	* <i>durno-</i> (zero grade + singulative * <i>-no-</i>)
* <i>déarna</i> , * <i>derna</i> , * <i>deàrna</i>	Irish, Gaelic	palm of the hand	* <i>derna-</i> (full grade + singulative * <i>-na-</i>)
<i>Durnomagus</i> , <i>Durnacos</i> , <i>Dagodurnus</i>	Continental Celtic (Gaulish)	related to the hand	* <i>durno-</i> (zero grade in place- and personal names)

The full grade **derna-* “palm” and the zero grade **durno-* “fist” reflect the expected ablaut distribution for a singulative formation on a CeRC root: full grade in the semantically unmarked state (the open hand), zero grade in the stronger state (the closed fist). Two states of the hand, expressed by two ablaut grades of the same root with the same body-part suffix.

4.3 The compounds as confirmation

The body-part meaning of Celtic **durno-* is confirmed by compound formations whose semantics admit no other reading. Proto-Celtic **are-durnon* (Old Irish **aurdorn*, Welsh **arddwrn*, Breton **arzorn*) means “wrist” — literally “the part proximal to the hand.” Proto-Celtic **ambi-durnos* (Old Irish **imdorn*) means “sword hilt” — literally “the around-the-hand thing.” Neither compound makes sense with “fist” as the base; both are transparent and natural with “hand.”

Matasóvić’s *Etymological Dictionary of Proto-Celtic* (2009, s.v. **durno-*) marks the form as of unknown etymology. The present hypothesis offers the missing Indo-European etymology. The Greek-Celtic comparison was made already by Fick and Prellwitz in the nineteenth century — Irish

**derna* was compared with Greek δῶρον in its palm-breadth sense and both were referred to PIE **der-*. The philological intuition was sound; what was lacking was the full phonological account and the Anatolian semantic confirmation.

5. The Baltic evidence: Latvian *dūre*

Latvian **dūre*, **dūris* “fist” enters the cognate set as a third Indo-European witness. Schrijver (1995: 58) lists it explicitly among the “possible cognates” of Welsh **dwrn* and analyzes the long *ū* as reflecting earlier **uH*. The form stands as independent evidence — from a third branch (Baltic), in a third semantic domain (the closed hand as a discrete object) — for a root with *u*-vocalism, possibly with a laryngeal extension, in the body-part lexicon.

Derksen’s *Etymological Dictionary of the Baltic Inherited Lexicon* (2015) takes an agnostic stance on the Baltic **dur-* family, provisionally separating it from PIE **der-/dir-*. The form is isolated within Baltic, with no Lithuanian cognate. These are real reasons for caution. **dūre* is one piece of evidence in a comparative cluster — useful but not load-bearing. It is consistent with Path B above: if the IE root shape was **duH-r-* in zero grade, Latvian **dūre* with long *ū* reflecting **uH* is the expected outcome. Beekes’s observation that “both branches point to PIE **u*” is, on this reading, a description of the original root vocalism, not an objection to connection with δῶρον.

6. The Italic evidence: Latin *dōnum* and *dare*

Latin preserves both ablaut grades of the root in a single verbal paradigm: long *ō* in **dō* (1sg present), short *a* in **dare*, **dat*. The nominal derivative **dōnum* “gift” is morphologically analyzable as the o-grade root + **-no-* suffix: **dōr-no-* with regular development of **-rn-* to Latin **-n-* (as in **corn-ū* vs. κέρως).

The advantage of our reading is structural: Latin **dōnum* “gift” and Celtic **durno-* “fist” are morphologically parallel formations on the same root with the same suffix, differing only in ablaut grade (o-grade in Italic, zero grade in Celtic). The two derivations of the same suffixed nominal — one for “gift” in Italic and one for “fist” in Celtic — are exact morphological reflexes of the give/take semantic polarity as it cuts across the family: the same body-part root, the same nominal formation, two senses lexicalized in two branches.

7. The Anatolian and semantic question

7.1 The Hittite paradigm

Kloekhorst (2008: 928–930) documents the paradigm for *dā-/d-* “to take”:

Form	Hittite	Notes
1sg.pres.act.	<i>dāḥḥe / dāḥḥi</i>	strong stem <i>dā-</i>
3sg.pres.act.	<i>dāi</i>	strong stem <i>dā-</i>
1pl.pres.act.	<i>tumēni, dāweni</i>	weak stem with /u/ or /aw/
3pl.pres.act.	<i>danzi</i>	weak stem with /a/ vocalism

Kloekhorst derives this paradigm from PIE **deh₃-* with regular ablaut. Kloekhorst (2013) has further argued that the initial stop in *dā-* was glottalized — written conventionally /t“ā-/ — and that this glottalization is the segmental trace of **h₃* in Anatolian. Norbruis (2021: 243 n.2) follows this analysis and extends it to the Luwian outcome *l-*. On the architecture of Paper 3, this is entirely consistent: the laryngeal **h₃* is a real phoneme, present as a derivational extension suffix **-h₃-* on **de-*, and leaving real traces in Anatolian. Its presence in the verbal paradigm does not bear on the nominal reconstruction **der-* proposed here.

7.2 Norbruis 2021: independent semantic support

The most consequential development in the Anatolian literature for our hypothesis is semantic, not phonological. Norbruis (2021: 243–249), in a Leiden dissertation chapter on the etymology of **deh₃-*, argues that the original meaning of this root was “to take,” not “to give.” His reasoning is independent of any non-standard reconstruction: he reviews every parallel adduced for “give → take” semantic developments and shows they actually support the opposite direction. He then proposes that the original meaning was “to take,” with the post-Anatolian shift to “to give” running through an intermediate stage “to bring/deliver” — paralleled by English *to take to*, Biblical Hebrew *lāqah*, and Old Norse *fá* “to take; to give.” Norbruis stays with the formal reconstruction **deh₃-*, but his semantic finding is decoupleable from the formal question.

This is an independent argument from a specialist Anatolianist, in a published Leiden dissertation, that arrives at substantially the same semantic picture our hypothesis proposes: the original meaning was something concrete and physical, and the abstract “give” meaning is secondary. Mayrhofer (1992: 715), in the EWAia entry on Sanskrit *DĀ¹* “to give,” similarly derives the secondary root *DAD* “to hold, preserve” from *DĀ¹* via the middle voice “to take for oneself.” The plausibility of the connection between abstract giving and concrete physical handling is built into the standard treatment. Our hypothesis adds one further step: that the body-part root behind these connections was lexicalized as **der-*, and the cognate cluster δῶρον/δάρις/Celtic **durno-*/Latvian **dūre* is its surviving residue.

8. Beekes’s objection: Celtic and Latvian

Beekes’s *Etymological Dictionary of Greek* (2010), in its second lemma for δῶρον (“palm-breadth”), states: “Further Celt. words, like OIr. *dorn*, as well as Latv. *dure*, *duris* “fist”, have been connected, but both branches point to PIE **u*, which excludes any relationship with δῶρον.”

This objection is addressed by the two paths above. Under Path A (Morris Jones’s raising rule), the surface *u* does not witness PIE root vocalism, and Beekes’s inference fails. Under Path B (Schrijver and the majority), the *u* is original — but then Beekes’s observation that “both branches point to PIE **u*” is evidence about the root shape **deuH-r-*. δῶρον comes from the full grade of this extended root via Schrijver’s own **du-* > *δ-* mechanism. Path B is more consonant with Schrijver’s framework and the Gaulish evidence.

On the Latvian form: Derksen’s agnosticism about the Baltic **dur-* family is itself relevant. The form is too contested in the Baltic literature to support the weight Beekes places on it as a decisive objection. It is one piece of evidence in a comparative cluster — not decisive in either direction.

9. Mayrhofer’s rejection: a distinction

Mayrhofer (1992: 703), in EWAia, explicitly rejects an independent IE root **der* ~ **derk* attributed to Grassmann (1875: 625) and “later authors.” His verdict: the data “does not establish an independent IE root form” and the relevant senses are better derived from the standard **DAR¹* “to break open” + the prefix *ā-*.

The hypothesis Mayrhofer rejects and the hypothesis we propose are not the same. Mayrhofer rejects Grassmann’s **der-* on the basis of Sanskrit *ādara-* “esteem, respect” — a specific semantic field that Grassmann attributed to a separate root meaning something like “to regard, pay attention.” We propose **der-* “hand, open palm” — a body-part root with a completely different evidence base: the cognate cluster δῶρον (gift; palm-breadth) / δάρις (hand-span) / Celtic **durno-* (fist) / Celtic **derna-* (palm) / Latvian **dūre* (fist). Mayrhofer did not consider this body-part hypothesis when he rejected Grassmann’s. Our hypothesis is a different proposal on different grounds, and survives Mayrhofer’s rejection of Grassmann’s.

We acknowledge that the pattern — two different **der-* hypotheses, both rejected for different reasons — invites observation. We note in response: the hypothesis we propose is constrained by specific cognate evidence on the comparative table since Pokorny (IEW 203), and was

independently brought to attention by Schrijver in 1995 in full awareness of Mayrhofer's 1992 rejection. The "obscure" verdict on *δωρ-/δαρ-/Celtic *durno-/Latvian *dũre* is the live scholarly judgment our paper is responding to. Mayrhofer's rejection of a different **der-* is a separate matter.

10. Conclusion

PIE **der-* "hand, open palm" — or its laryngeal-extended variant **deuH-r-* — offers a unified reading of a comparative cluster that the specialist literature has acknowledged for over a century without converging on a satisfactory etymology. Greek *δῶρον* in its dual attestation (gift, palm-breadth), Hesychian *ἄρις* (hand-span), Old Irish **dorn* / Welsh **dwrn* / Breton **dorn* (fist), Old Irish **derna* (palm), Gaulish *Durnomagus* (place-name with the hand-stem), Latvian **dũre* (fist with long *ũ*) — these forms cluster around a single body-part meaning across six branches of the family. Schrijver (1995: 58) lists the Greek, Celtic, and Baltic members as "possible cognates" and describes the formal relation between the Greek alternants as "obscure." Our hypothesis is one possible answer to the question Schrijver flagged as open.

The give-verbs in Greek, Latin, Sanskrit, and Lithuanian, and the take-verb in Hittite, descend from this body-part root through a semantic development from concrete handling to abstract transference — a development that Norbruis (2021) has independently argued for on Anatolian morphological grounds. On the three-paper architecture developed in Papers 2 and 3, the nominal **der-* and the verbal **deh₃-* are siblings: both derivatives of the bare hand-element **de-*, with **-r-* yielding the body-part word and **-h₃-* yielding the give-verb. Paper 1's contribution is the lexical evidence that the nominal branch is real.

The broader network of **der-* derivatives — including the verbal root **dher-* "to hold, maintain" and its reflex in Sanskrit *dharma*, and the directional verb **terh₂-* "to cross over" — is mapped in the future-research section of Paper 3 of this project (Chavis & Claude 2026c, §7).

Our verdict: the puzzle is real. The dual attestation of *δῶρον*, the Schrijver cognate cluster, and the Norbruis semantic finding constitute a body of evidence the standard reconstruction has not entirely addressed. The body-part etymology we propose engages this evidence directly. Whether the correct reconstruction proves to be **der-*, or **deuH-r-*, or remains **deh₃-* with a body-part origin recoverable by some other formal route, the substantive insight — that the hand is older than the gift in this root family — deserves to remain on the table.

Statement of contributions

This paper was produced through sustained collaboration between J.M. Chavis (human author) and Claude (Anthropic) across multiple sessions and model generations. The central hypothesis originates with Chavis. The identification of the two attested senses of Greek *δῶρον* — gift and palm-breadth — as a single word at two stages of semantic development was Chavis's core insight. Chavis directed the research agenda throughout, made all fundamental decisions about scope and framing, and chose to publish with full disclosure of the collaborative method through co-authorship.

Versions 1–20 were produced with a Sonnet-class Claude model. Version 21 (Opus 4.7) corrected errors in the Hittite paradigm, identified the Kloekhorst (2013) and Norbruis (2021) literature, and shifted the epistemic posture from claiming the hypothesis correct to offering it as an alternative worth considering. Version 22 restored four pieces of mainstream-literature engagement that v21 had compressed. Version 23 is a comprehensive structural rewrite integrating the three-paper framework: since Papers 2 and 3 establish that **der-* and **deh₃-* are siblings (both derivatives of bare **de-*), Paper 1 need not argue against **deh₃-* but alongside it, and the framing has been updated accordingly. The probability estimate of approximately 15–20% for the substantive thesis is carried forward.

Claude's contributions are the product of an AI system without persistent memory between sessions. The intellectual continuity of the project was provided by Chavis through systematic

transcript management. Claude did not initiate the project, does not have an independent stake in its conclusions, and cannot take legal or institutional responsibility for the claims made here. That responsibility rests entirely with Chavis.

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